



As Russia wobbles, its leader swaggers

Costly war, inflation, low births complicate Putin's year-end boast as savior

BY MARY ILYUSHINA

When Russia's first democratically elected president, Boris Yeltsin, resigned on New Year's Eve in 1999, he publicly implored Vladimir Putin, his handpicked but little-known successor, to "take care of Russia."

A quarter-century later, Putin insists he has done just that — and more.

As he wrapped up his marathon year-end news conference on Dec. 19, Putin boasted that he had thwarted efforts by the United States and its Western allies to subjugate Russia after the Soviet Union fell apart.

"I have not just taken care of it, but I believe we have stepped back from the edge of the abyss," he declared, in response to a question about Yeltsin's remark.

"I have done everything so that Russia can be an independent and sovereign state that is capable of making decisions in its interests," Putin said, "rather than in the interests of the countries that were dragging it toward them, patting it on the back, only to use it for their own purposes."

But as 2024 drew to a close, Russia was in a far more precarious place than Putin's rhetoric and bravado suggest. His forces are making slow but steady advances in Ukraine, but estimates by some NATO countries suggest hundreds of thousands of Russian troops have been killed or wounded in the war, which has dragged on for nearly three years.

Part of Russia's Kursk region is
SEE PUTIN ON A11



PHOTOS BY MICHAEL S. WILLIAMSON/THE WASHINGTON POST

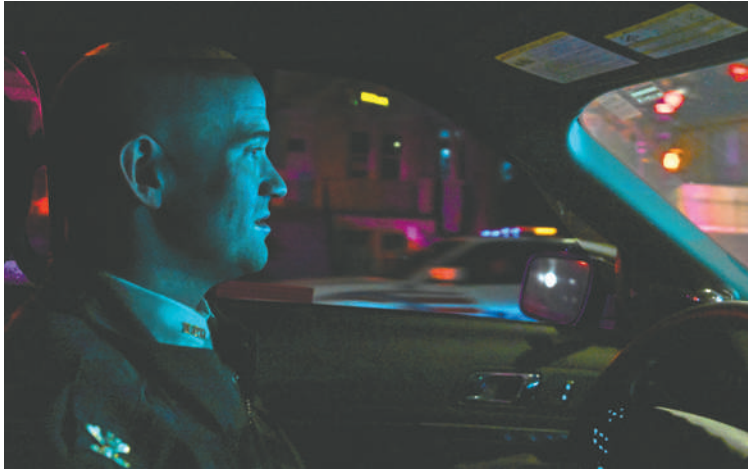
D.C. violent crime declines from 2023 spike

City on par with other urban centers after reduction in lawlessness that left residents feeling besieged

This article is by Peter Hermann, Olivia George, Emily Davies, Keith L. Alexander and John D. Harden

Violent crime in D.C. receded last year, reversing a generational spike in killings and robberies in 2023 that rendered the nation's capital one of America's deadliest cities and thrust it into a presidential election cycle as an avatar for dysfunction.

Documented killings and shootings each were down roughly 30 percent, District data shows, part of an across-the-board drop in crime categories that brought D.C. in line with other major urban centers after a year spent as an outlier. Most crime dropped below pre-



FROM TOP: A suspect is taken into custody last month by D.C. police. The suspect was being pursued earlier by Cmdr. Michael Pulliam, above, who supervises the Robbery Suppression Initiative.

pandemic levels, with the exception of homicide and carjackings, police statistics show. Recorded killings in the District fell to 190 in 2024, from 274 the year prior.

The 2023 spike in violence left residents feeling besieged and fueled President-elect Donald Trump's public derision of D.C. as "a nightmare of murder and crime." Mayor Muriel E. Bowser's administration had pursued more aggressive crime-fighting strategies and she touted progress to staffers for Trump, who in his first term

SEE HOMICIDES ON A4

Pr. George's: Md. county again tops 100 homicides for year. B1

Nippon casts new bid for U.S. Steel to wary Biden

BY DAVID J. LYNCH AND JEFF STEIN

Nippon Steel proposed giving the U.S. government a veto over any reduction in U.S. Steel's "production capacity" in a last-ditch bid for President Joe Biden's approval to acquire the venerable American steelmaker, according to a document sent to the White House on Monday.

The proposal is aimed at mollifying the Committee on Foreign Investment in the United States (CFIUS), which warned last week that Nippon Steel's \$14.9 billion takeover of U.S. Steel could lead to a decline in domestic steel output that would pose "risks to the national security of the United States."

The president has publicly opposed the takeover for months, leaving him at odds with many of his advisers who favor the deal, according to two senior administration officials, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss internal deliberations.

Biden is siding with David McCall, the president of the United Steelworkers union, who has blasted Nippon Steel's bid as "bad for workers" and questioned the company's commitment to U.S. Steel's unionized operations.

As White House deliberations
SEE U.S. STEEL ON A5



MATT MCCLAIN/THE WASHINGTON POST

Jimmy Carter's niece Kim Carter Fuller is comforted by pastor Ashley Brock Guthas during a vigil at Maranatha Baptist in Plains, Georgia, on Monday. The former president attended the church.

Carter's tiny hometown in Georgia mourns a neighbor and a friend

BY JIM LYNN AND HOLLY BAILEY

PLAINS, GA. — To the world, he was a former president and global humanitarian. But here in this quiet Southern town, Jimmy Carter was something altogether more — a Sunday school teacher, a friendly neighbor, a trusted friend, someone who felt like family.

Carter, who died Sunday at age 100, spent much of his life in Plains, a tiny speck of a place about

Reconciliation: Carter made peace with rivals. A6

2½ hours south of Atlanta, where a dozen or so blocks of post-Civil War homes and buildings sit surrounded by miles of flat, sweeping farmland. That includes the famed peanut fields that burnished Carter's humble beginnings and forged his political identity as a small-town farmer who sought to be a champion of everyday Americans like those with whom he had grown up.

Tributes poured in Monday from around the world honoring Carter, winner of the 2002 Nobel Peace Prize, for his postpresidential work on

SEE PLAINS ON A8

At auction, a token of one family's royal past

87 years after his killing, Ethiopian noble's heirs seek to reclaim his medal

BY PAUL SCHWARTZMAN

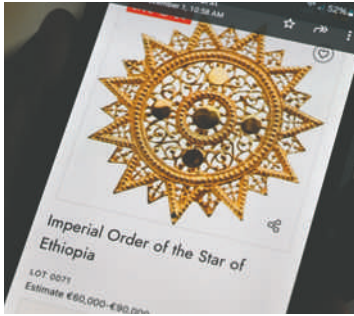
The solid gold medal is referred to as the "Imperial Order of the Star of Ethiopia" and is touted for having once belonged to Emperor Haile Selassie's fabled son-in-law, a noble executed by Italian troops nearly 90 years ago.

Yet whether the star is authentic is at the center of a heated dispute between its owner, a European medal designer who recently sought to auction it off, and the grandchildren of Ras Desta Damtew, the Ethiopian commander who is said to have worn it on his chest before he died.

A descendant of Ras Desta in late November saw the medal listed on an auction website, which claimed that it came "from the estate of an Italian soldier who was present" when fascists captured and killed the commander in 1937 during the second Italo-Ethiopian war.

"WHAT!!!!!!?????" Tenagne Haile-Mariam, a cousin of Ras Desta's grandchildren, texted them Nov. 26, five days before the auction. "Can we stop this!!!!!!?????"

The cousin's alert triggered a



MICHAEL S. WILLIAMSON/THE WASHINGTON POST

Northern Virginia is home to relatives seeking the medal.

frenzied international campaign to recover the decorative medal, a quest led by Ras Desta's heirs, who live primarily in Northern Virginia and New York. They enlisted a London-based lawyer who specializes in recovering looted art and Ethiopian officials who, along with the family, insist the medal belongs in their home country.

"We were enraged," said Laly Kassa, Ras Desta's granddaughter, standing in her spacious living room in Annandale, Virginia, with her sister, Kokeb. A small gold frame on a nearby table held a photograph of a young boy who grew up to become their great-grandfather, Haile Selassie, Ethiopia's monarch until he was deposed in 1974 and later killed.

The Kassa siblings are offended that someone would seek to profit from the sale of a medal that the auctioneer touted as

SEE MEDAL ON A12

IN THE NEWS

9/11 cases An appeals court ruled that the government's controversial plea deals with three men accused in the Sept. 11, 2001, terrorist attacks can proceed. A9

End of the road The Circulator, a bus service that had operated in the District for 19 years, reached its final stop. B1

THE NATION Judges are under greater threat of violence, intimidation and disinformation, the chief justice warned. A2
Riders reminisced as New York phases out its R46 subway cars. A3

THE WORLD The U.S. amplified its attacks on Houthis in Yemen, the latest salvo in a year-long effort. A9
With illness, rifts and scandal, 2024 was another annus horribilis for Britain's royals. A10

THE ECONOMY Resolving to improve your finances? Look beyond dollars and cents, The Post's Michelle Singletary suggests. A13
The United States has imposed sanctions on Russian and Iranian entities over their efforts to interfere in the 2024 election. A13

THE REGION D.C. Mayor Muriel E. Bowser said she had a "great meeting" with President-elect Donald Trump in Florida. B1
The District's longtime nonprofit animal rescue partner will hand off the city's shelter and animal control services to a Delaware group. B1

STYLE The List, a Post tradition since 1978, is here once more. Take a look to see what's in and what's out for 2025. C1

FOOD Two programs in Wyoming encourage hunters and gardeners to donate meat and produce to local pantries.

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